that had enabled the BJP to dominate the non-tribal seats. Soren launched the Maiya Samman Yojana in August, a scheme offering a monthly stipend of Rs 1,000 to economically disadvantaged women aged 18 to 50. Over five million women were enrolled, and money started rolling into their bank accounts. Targeting this universal, segment-neutral demographic of eligible voters was a masterstroke. The BJP, sensing the impact, countered by promising Rs 2,100 a month, but Soren was one step ahead. A day before the model code of conduct came into effect, he announced an increase in the stipend to Rs 2,500. There were other freebies too, like a waiver of Rs 3,500 crore in electricity dues, benefiting 4 million households.

The results told the tale. Women voters turned out in record numbers,

The BJP lost badly in the 28 tribal-reserved seats. Its 'infiltration' narrative was resoundingly rejected by voters everywhere

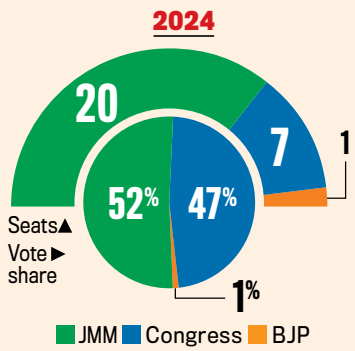
with 70.46 per cent casting their ballots, compared to 65.06 per cent of eligible male voters. In 68 out of 81 seats, women outvoted men, shaping the outcome and giving INDIA a crucial edge even in non-reserved seats. A Lokniti CSDS post-poll survey confirms women voters favoured INDIA and Maiya Samman was a factor. Also, over half of those voters who prioritised state matters supported INDIA, with one-third preferring Hemant as CM.

Altogether, Jharkhand has 44 non-reserved seats, which have been a BJP support base. Here, the saffron party could only hold its 2019 tally of 17, while the JMM improved its tally from nine to 12 seats. The Congress took seven and the RJD three. The tactics bore fruit even in the nine Scheduled Caste-reserved seats, where the BJP's 2019 tally of six seats came down to three, whereas the JMM, Congress and the RJD together bagged five.

The other X-factor was Kalpana. By the time Hemant resumed office, he could find in his wife an ally who was developing a formidable political nous. With a natural flair for connecting with crowds and fluent in Santhali, Bangla and Hindi (besides English), she addressed over 100 rallies and was especially well received by women.

TRIBAL SCORECARD

Total ST-reserved Seats: 28



AN INDIA BLOC SWEEP

JMM

Contested 21 ST seats, won 20, with 51.62% vote share in these seats

CONGRESS

Contested 7 ST seats, won all, with 47.32% vote share

BJP

Contested 25 ST seats overall but won just one

Triumph in Tribal Areas

The BJP, acutely aware of its vulnerability among Jharkhand's tribal voters—who constitute 26.3 per cent of the population—did make a concerted effort to woo them. A year ago, it appointed Babulal Marandi, a Santhal tribal leader like Hemant Soren, to helm its Jharkhand unit. Alongside Marandi, the BJP deployed three former tribal CMs—Arjun Munda, Madhu Koda, and Champai Soren—to strengthen its tribal outreach.

However, Soren, buoyed by widespread tribal sympathy following his arrest, skilfully positioned himself as the sole custodian of Adivasi interests and *asmita* (pride). His campaign highlighted an "existential threat to tribal identity under a BJP-led government". Soren's push for a 1932-based domicile policy for government jobs and recognition of the Sarna religion as a key part of tribal identity resonated strongly, with the CSDS survey highlighting widespread support for the latter. Tying it all up was the urgent appeal to restore the rule of tribals against a "feudal" BJP that falsely implicated a son of the soil. The strategy paid off spectacularly, with the JMM-led alliance sweeping 27 of the 28 tribal-reserved seats. The JMM alone secured 20 of the 21 tribal seats it contested, while the Congress claimed all its seven tribal seats.

The scale of the BJP's defeat in ST-reserved seats was huge. Even high-profile candidates struggled: Meera Munda and Geeta Koda, wives of former CMs Arjun Munda and Madhu Koda, both lost. Champai Soren held on to Saraikela, but his son, Babulal Soren, suffered a defeat.

A section of BJP leaders acknowledge strategic missteps. For instance, Marandi's failure was partly attributed to his decision to contest from a non-tribal seat, which undermined the party's own need to use him to shore up its credibility among tribals. Privately, many Jharkhand BJP leaders concede the party's overemphasis on the narrative of "Bangladeshi infiltration" backfired. Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, serving as the party's co-in-charge for Jharkhand, spearheaded a campaign on alleged infil-